From Request Fulfillers To Outcome Owners

Digital services at the DMV

Does this feel familiar?

Endless request queue

We're buried in feature requests with no clear way to know which ones will actually make a difference for the community.

Timeline extension

A project's timeline and budget are re-estimated halfway through, forcing our partners to scramble and eroding their trust in our ability to deliver.

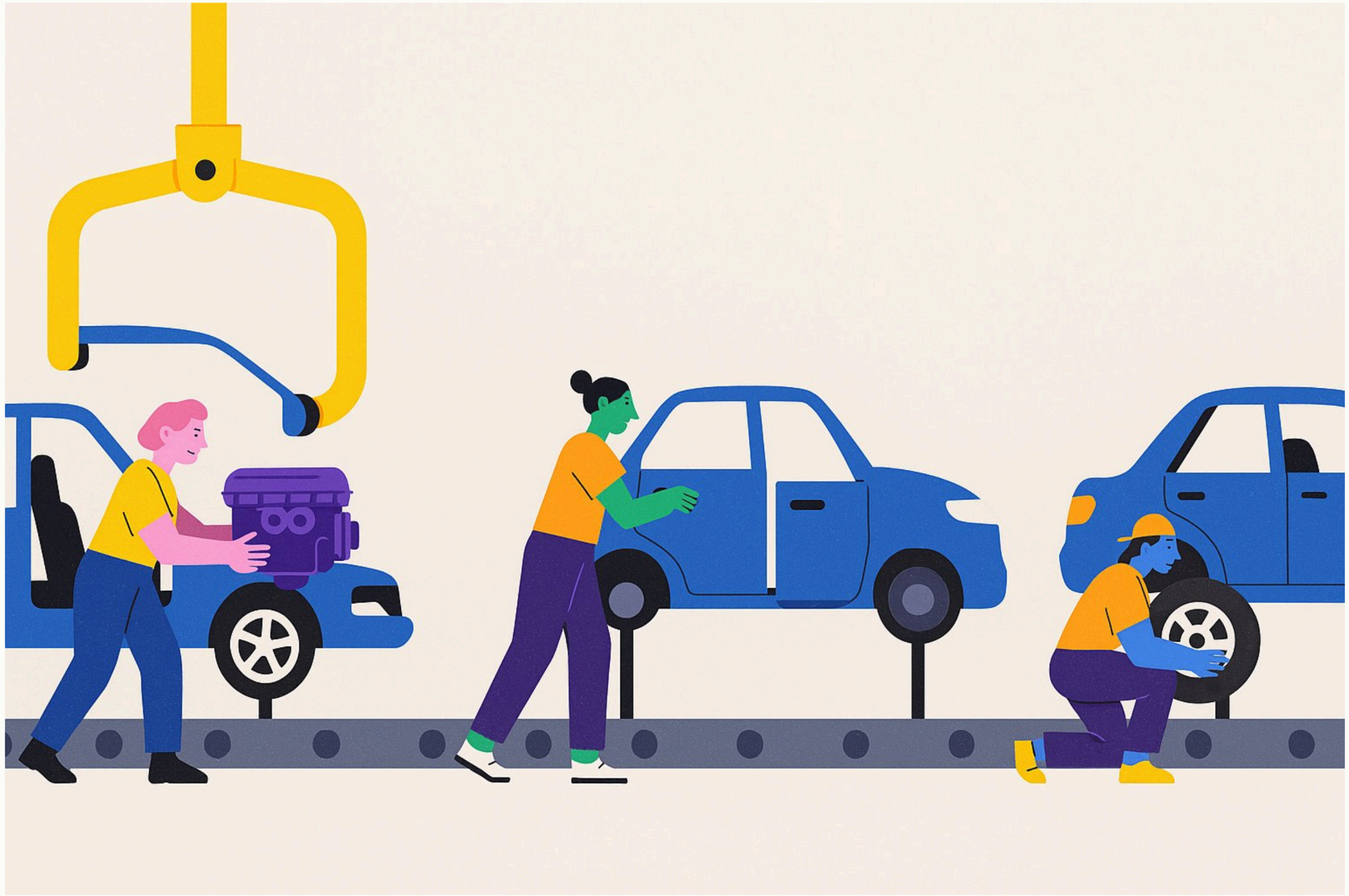
"Successful" failures

We deliver a project on time and on budget, but our partners are still unhappy and the core problem isn't truly solved.

IT "black box"

Our partners see us as an order-taking group that's slow to respond, and our staff feels like they're just closing tickets instead of thinking strategically.

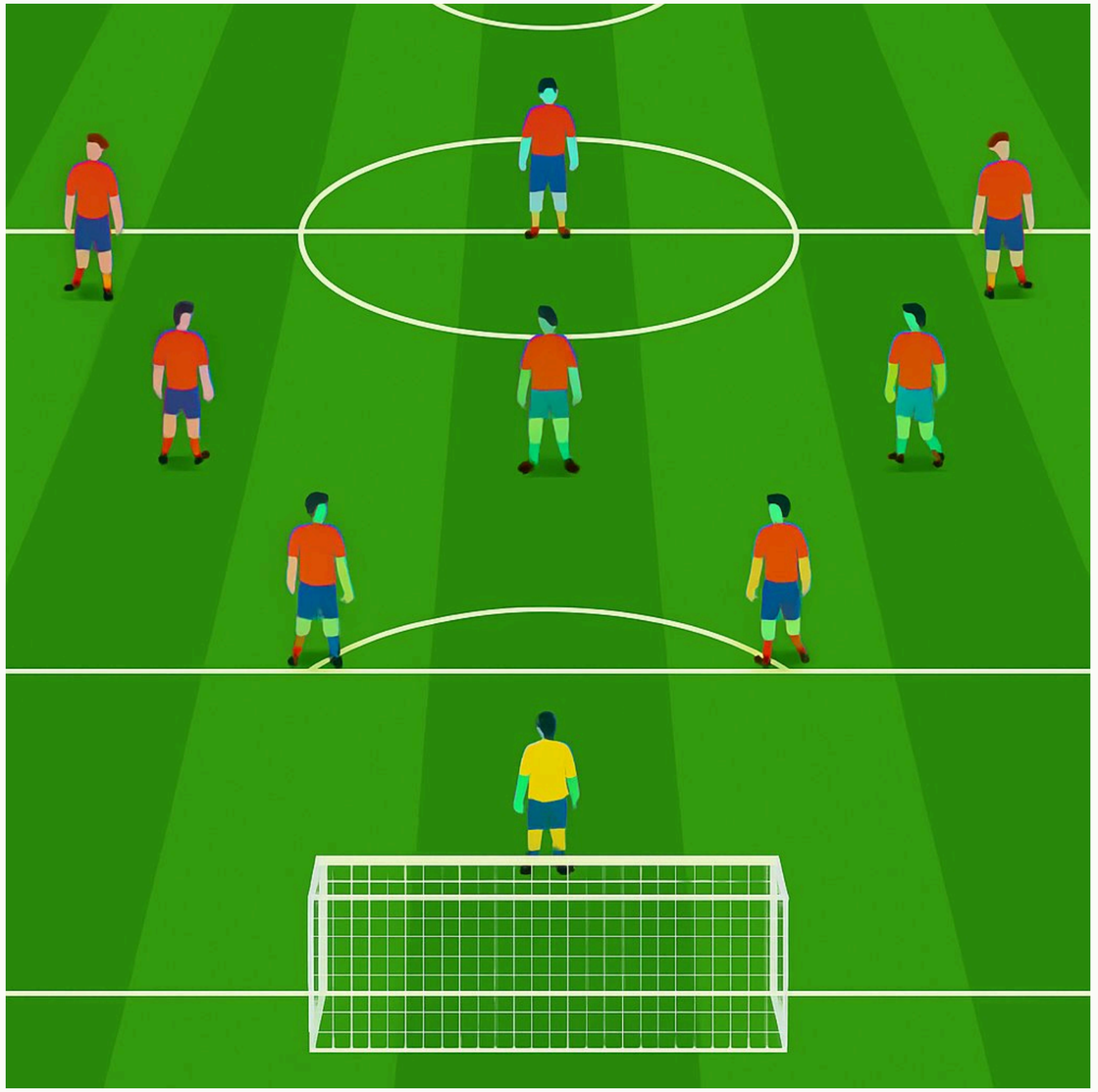
How we think we work





How we actually work

How we should work



We are pulled in every direction

> Success is defined by our ability to appease competing stakeholders, not by the impact we deliver.

> Our teams spend their energy balancing internal priorities, not maximizing public value.

> There's no single, clear direction of "forward."





Two competing systems

Projects

One system provides "project" work and has its own specific process with roles and responsibilities.

Operations

Another system is managed by different people with different processes, roles and responsibilities.

The challenge

People are caught in between these two systems, and have no way to reconcile them.

Temporary efforts vs enduring value

Project

A **temporary** effort to deliver a **specific output**, like a system upgrade, a new feature, or an installation. It has a defined start and end.

Product (or service)

An **ongoing** thing you build that **delivers value to people**. It's ongoing and evolves.

Projects aren't the problem; they fit work with a clear end. **Our problem:** we also treat enduring services (like HR systems, data and analytics, or a resident-facing service) like temporary projects. We fund them, build them, and "operationalize" them, but the user's need for them is continuous, evolving and always increasing.

The shift that changes everything

From project to product, for the work that never ends

	Project	Product
Mindset	Outputs	Outcomes
Goal	Deliver a thing	Create a change
Metric	On time, on budget, built to spec	Measurable improvement in a user or business metric
	"We built what you asked for."	"We achieved the outcome you need."

Our process reflects our mindset

Traditional process

Waterfall

"Big upfront requirements, big risk, and we only find out if we were right at the very end."

Iterative delivery

Wagile (fake agile)

"This is agile in name only. We're just building a predefined plan faster. It's a faster assembly line, but we're still building the wrong car if the plan was wrong."

Product focus

Lean, HCD, Agile

"This is where we need to go. A continuous flow where we discover, deliver, and learn. This allows us to adapt and ensures we're always working on the most valuable thing."

This is happening

This isn't a radical experiment; it's about adopting a proven model for public service.

The **City of Philadelphia**, for example, is building internal teams focused on improving services before applying new technology, a core tenet of the product mindset.

Franklin County, Ohio has reorganized to focus on digital services, with product managers leading application development teams.

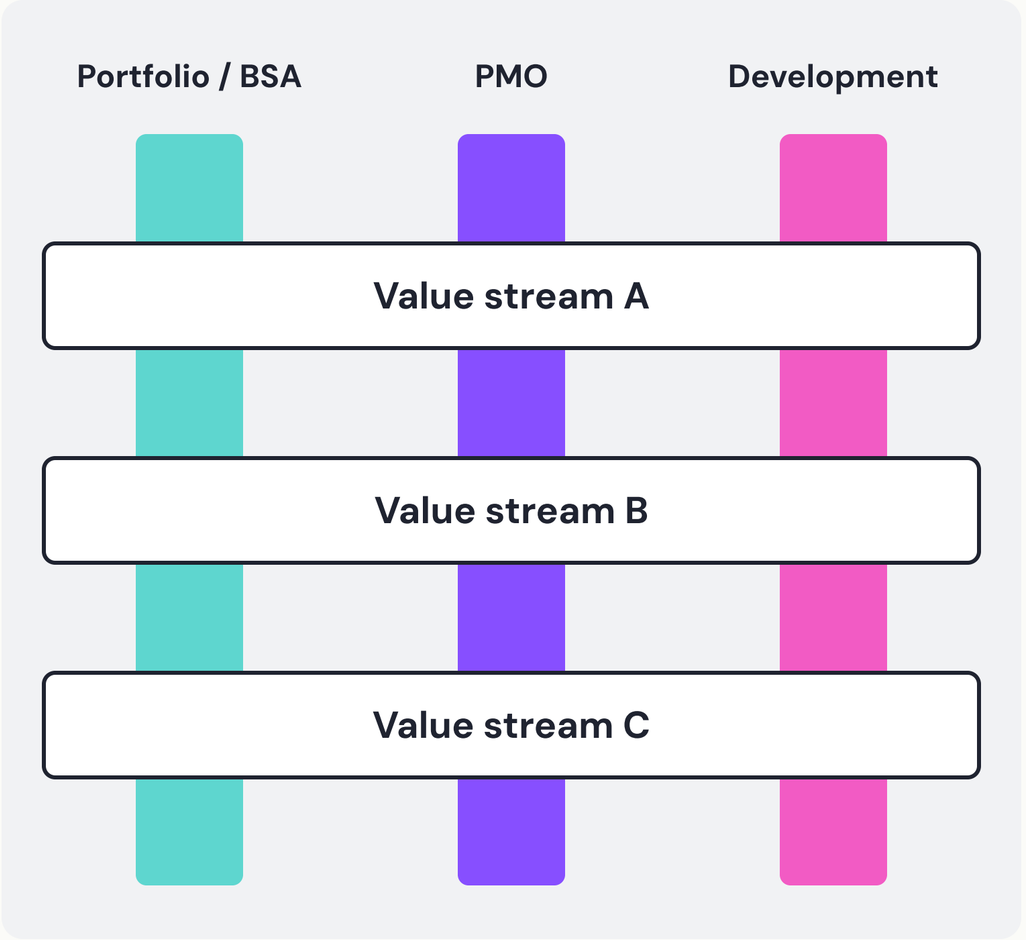
Colorado and Pennsylvania have both established state-level digital services to keep offering better digital experiences to their residents.

This is the model used in the **private sector** as well as at the federal level (USDS, 18F), and across the **United Kingdom** and **Canada**.

Right now, we're organized around projects and departments. This creates silos and handoffs.

A better model is organizing around **value streams**: the end-to-end activities that deliver value to a customer (a community member or internal user).

This means shifting from temporary project teams to **persistent, long-lived teams** that own an outcome.



Everything fits in a value stream

	Community	Staff	Enabling
Focus	Delivering services directly to the public.	Empowering DMV employees to do their jobs effectively.	Providing foundational platforms for all other streams.
Example	A resident's journey to renew a vehicle registration without a trip to the office.	The internal HR system used for payroll.	The secure network, cloud infrastructure, and developer tools.
Goal	Improve public access and community outcomes.	Improve internal efficiency and effectiveness.	Increase the speed, reliability, and security of all teams.



Not just for websites

Enterprise systems (HR, payroll)

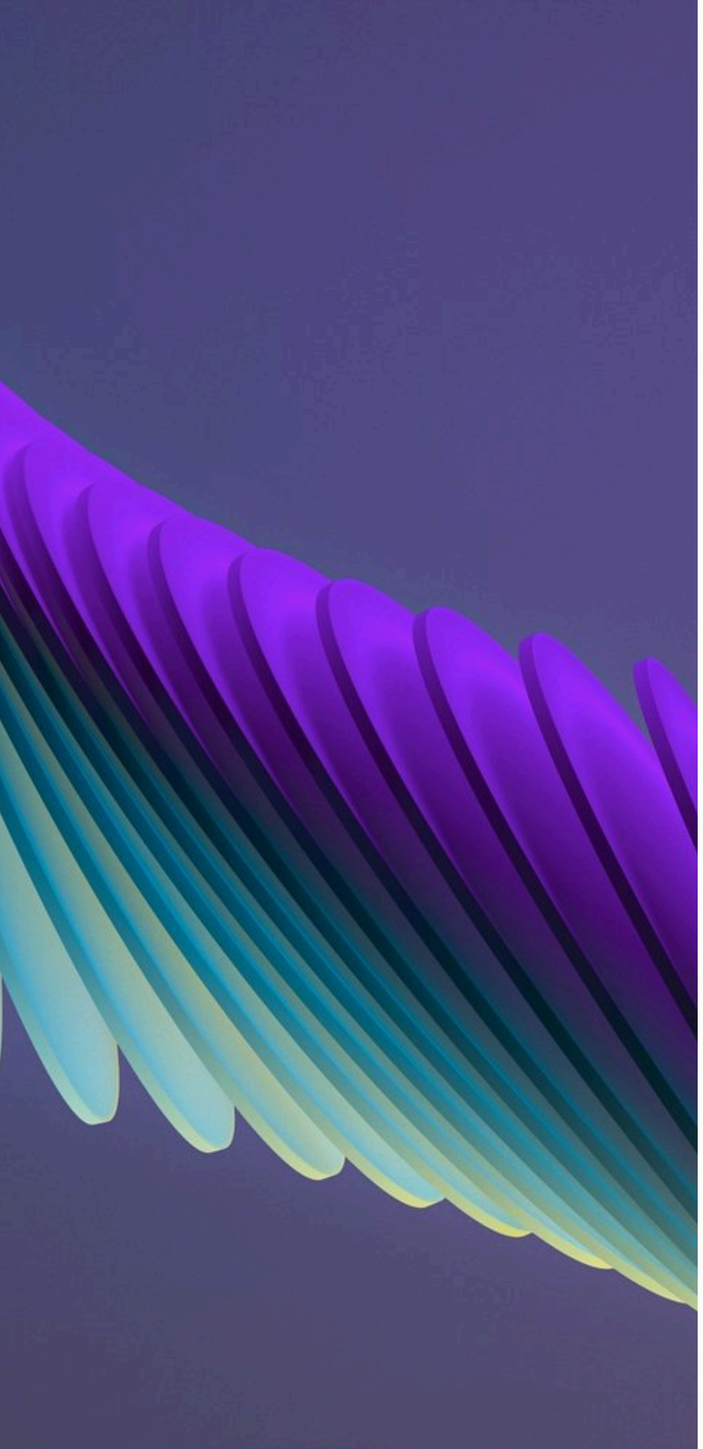
This is a staff value stream. The "product" is the employee's experience. The "outcome" is less time on admin and better workforce planning.

Data and BI

This is an enabling value stream. The "product" is the organization's ability to make decisions. The "outcome" is a measurable improvement in a department's key measure.

Vehicle renewals

This is a community value stream. The "product" is a resident's journey to renew without a trip. The "outcome" is fewer trips to the office and fewer calls asking how.



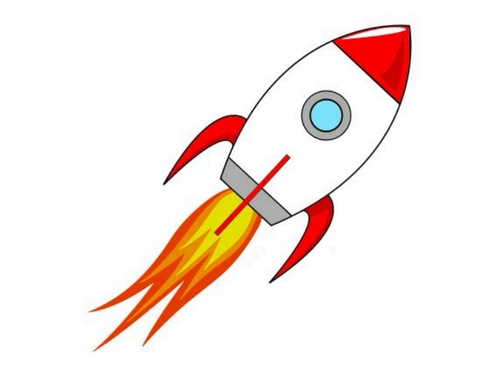
A shift in our roles

This new model doesn't change who our people are; it changes the system they work in. It lets us redirect their valuable expertise to a more impactful set of roles.

From	To
Documenting requirements given to us by stakeholders.	*Investigating the underlying problems to make sure we're solving the right thing.*
Managing fixed schedules and delivering a predefined scope.	*Facilitating the continuous flow of value and adapting to what we learn.*
Tracking the status of disconnected projects.	*Guiding strategic investments to achieve measurable outcomes for the people we serve.*

How we make this transition

This transformation isn't a top-down reorganization. It's a movement that proves its value one success story at a time.



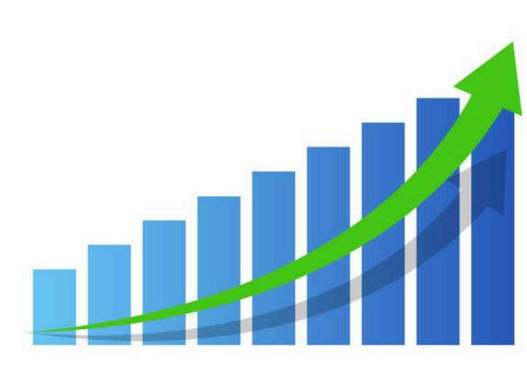
1 / Pilot

We start with one or two teams. We give them the air cover to work in this new way. We let them demonstrate what's possible.



2 / Attract

Pilot success creates demand. We use the wins to change the conversation from "what do you want?" to "what outcome can we achieve together?"



3 / Scale

We scale only after we've proven it works here, in our own culture, and have a repeatable pattern for success.

Better value, less risk, happier people

This new model directly solves our most common frustrations.

Reducing risk

Continuous feedback stops us building the wrong thing. We can deliver value sooner.

Increasing value

An outcome focus means we're always working on the most important problem.

Improving partnerships

We become true partners with the business, sharing ownership of the results.

Empowering staff

We elevate our teams from specialists to strategic problem solvers, increasing job satisfaction.

Challenges

People change

This deeply affects people and how they see themselves within the system, and people generally don't like change.

We have to treat this change on the most human level possible: be open, listen, and communicate.

Financial framework

The way budgeting and accounting work is a structure that fights against this model.

We have to spend time with finance so the way our finances are set up ties costs to the value delivered.

Optics

This is a very new way of showing value. Results come sooner, but the reporting can feel counterintuitive at first.

We have to be transparent, communicate, and revamp how we report on our progress and our value.



Questions?